THE HAPPINESS ISSUE

UPLIFTING A COMMUNITY

A Sikh organisation is helping restore the dignity of the Sikligars, a proud nomadic community of Sikh weaponsmiths, tending to their health, housing and education needs

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GREATER COMMON GOOD
TSS president Tejdeep Kaur Menon with Sikh schoolchildren at a health camp in Hyderabad

TELANGANA SIKH SOCIETY
Telangana

Sikhs in the South have a history going back 300-odd years. The first of them came with Guru Gobind Singh, on his Deccan expedition in the early 18th century. Around 1832 came the Lahori Fauj, a Sikh contingent that was sent as a peacekeeping force by Maharaja Ranjit Singh to help the Nizam. In between fell the nomadic Sikhs, among them the Sikligars, weaponsmiths who, too, were part of the contingent that accompanied Guru Gobind Singh.

From these proud martial beginnings, the Sikhs in Telangana fell on bad days post-Independence. While the descendants of the Huzoori Sikhs went on to receive education and employment, the Sikligars survived on the margins, turning scrap into knives or utensils, repairing locks and keys, and selling them as they moved from village to village, unable to shake off their nomadic existence.

Things took a turn for the worse during the Covid years when the Sikligars could not step out to sell their wares and were reduced to penury. It was at this time that the Telangana Sikh Society (TSS), formed in 2018, stepped in. From community kitchens and supplying grains to financial support during the lockdown, the TSS moved forward to take care of their overall long-term health and housing needs and also equip them with better skills and education. So far, they have met the hospitalisation needs of over 1,500 patients. They held 18 health camps, which helped identify 5,000 patients afflicted with chronic illnesses, in need of hospitalisation or surgical intervention, or suffering from previously undiagnosed dental or eye issues. "Duty towards the downtrodden is integral to Sikhs," says Tejdeep Kaur Menon, a retired IPS officer, who was elected the TSS president for a second time in September 2023.